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Ted Piltzecker

Ted Piltzecker enjoys an active career as a vibraphonist, composer, educator and promoter of world music. He cites his time with the George Shearing Quintet as one of his most valuable learning experiences.

Ted was interviewed in Clinton, NY on October 10, 2019 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm very happy to have a vibe performance Ted Piltzecker on campus today, and I should say vibes player and educator and composer, arranger, pilot. If you made a pie chart and looked at your career, are the things you do sort of equal in amount?

TP: That's an interesting question. I think I get pretty intensely interested in various things and go at them for a while and then sometimes they become a little bit more on the back burner and I try to bring whatever I do to some level of competence that I — never get satisfied but some level of competence that's acceptable. So yes, I still love flying and I flew here and it's a habit I — it's really difficult to kick. It's very intoxicating. It's visual, it's visceral, and it's time when you have to think at a level that you don't think all the time. I mean when you're on final approach, you know, your mind is working a little bit differently than it works in normal life. You're concentrating and more focused. And I love that, it's just really fun. So that's another thing about flying I love. That's — I didn't come here to talk about flying but yes, it's part of me and I'm still very involved with it and I fly for the U.S. Coast Guard Auxiliary, I volunteer my time, so I do a lot of Coast Guard missions. But yeah, I'm very pleased to be able to sort of wrap that into the rest of my life.

MR: Yeah. Do you have to make sure you're not getting distracted by some recent composition that you're working on, and all of a sudden your mind starts going there, and meanwhile you're flying an airplane?

TP: Well one discipline helps the other. You always learn something from this endeavor or activity like it's applicable to something else. So the idea of focusing, when you're doing solos, when you're flying, the idea of having to not — consciously not be distracted, which we train to do, and so you can do the task, it helps sometimes on the bandstand. For instance, when you're — you know I fly with a lot of guys who have various experiences, most of them are older than me, and you know we may not be of the same political persuasions let's say, and it's a very divided, polarized country right now, as we know. But the time not to engage in those conversations, if you can call them conversations, is not in the cockpit, because it's distracting to the point where it's

dangerous. So that's a discipline you learn simply not to do that. And if it happens it's a liability, a real serious liability. So you don't talk about certain things by design, and you discipline yourself not to do that. So that kind of discipline sometimes can help your focus in other realms. Does that make sense to you?

MR: It does. And you demonstrated this morning quite well I thought, something not to do on the bandstand when you said, "Here's a rude accompanist."

TP: It scares me that I demonstrated being rude so well I guess.

MR: Well the students needed to see what you were talking about, and I thought you made it clear, overplaying and like, "Keep the spotlight on me" not over there.

TP: I think everybody aspires to the best kind of teamwork possible to come up with you know, and sometimes it's hard to just focus on what the total picture is. What is the band creating for the audience and you just contribute one part of that fabric. But yes, not overplaying and having a sense of the texture as it's unfolding. You don't have to play that chord or that note or this extra something necessarily because you can. And you know I can't say that I do it all the time but I can say that I aspire to doing it all the time, you know, to being judicious and to go make that perfect solo that never happens you know.

MR: Did you have an aha moment as a kid, like with music, that this could be something that I really want to pursue? Something that occurred, a recording or seeing somebody?

TP: I think it would be nice to say yes and like many artists can say, "When I was in fourth grade somebody came through town and I was knocked out and never forgot it." I don't think I ever had one of those. And I'm a little maybe different from a lot of other great — not great but other artists, that I just sort of did it and it was something I did pretty well and I — okay, well I guess I'll go to music school and I just meandered into music school and then I sort of got into it. I mean I didn't really have a moment in my childhood — my parents, my mother is from New Orleans, she used to play some Al Hirt songs when I was younger and that was — I used to listen to that and Louis Prima, and my sister who was older came with a Bill Evans album and I played it, and Miles, and I thought man, this music is from space, man. I couldn't understand it at all, especially Bill on "Blue In Green." And I said it just sounds so, it didn't make any sense to me. You know some people listen to Shostakovich or Schoenberg or something, you're not quite ready for it. And it wasn't until years later that of course "Blue In Green" has never been my favorite song to play, but I didn't have one of those early childhood moments. I went to Eastman and when I got to Eastman I heard a lot of great music. In fact, maybe one other thing. I had a high school choir director that, we played not showy music but we sang Brahms and you know, it was a really wonderful experience. I was the president of the choir, had the worst voice. But it was an engagement of music making that I sort of remember. That

was a really formative time I think artistically and aesthetically. Before that I played in a drum corps and that basically was functioning to get me off the streets and keep me out of trouble, which it did. I'm very thankful for that. Some of the guys that were hanging around at the time got into trouble. So my mom said get away from this gang, join the drum corps. There were no more drums left so they gave me a bugle and I played the bugle and then I got to high school and I played the trumpet, seemed to be the next thing, and all of a sudden I'm a trumpet major at Eastman.

MR: Oh, you were a trumpet major.

TP: That was my major at Eastman, the trumpet, a performance major. I was at first an education major and than I got into this place and I said wow, so this is what, how moving this thing can be. And I had basically no skills, I mean comparatively to other people that came in. I'm not — it was just amazing. Some of the other trumpet players were Al Vizzutti, and Vince DiMartino and Jeff Tysik was there. And you know, Joe Mosello. And that's the band I played with. I was playing fifth trumpet. And Chuck Mangione was the director. I'm at the end sort of sucking air and all those guys and I'm going, whoa. Just trying to hold on. But between that and all the classical music and hearing the trombone choir, Emory Remington, those things were memorable to me and you know reached into a part of me that I hadn't tapped into probably the same way. So I really fell in love with it then you know, and after that many other things started happening and then there were those monumental experiences that I heard — a lot of world music stuff, occasionally a jazz person, it could be anything. But I'm eclectic in my tastes. I'm not so much in the jazz head like probably many other people that have sat in this chair.

MR: I know what you mean. There's a lot of music out there.

TP: There's a lot of music out there.

MR: And I'm wondering, you're an educator now also. Do you think it's harder for students these days to be profoundly affected the way you were because there's so much out there and they have access to almost everything? Does it affect them the way it affected us?

TP: Well it's a great question, and a profound question because it relates to every aspect of our contemporary culture world wide today. I mean and there are many people that have addressed this: attention span difficulties, you know you can get into anything on a surface level in an instant by just a couple of clicks. And so yes, the answer is I think, unfortunately I do think it's harder. Yet it's still happening, it still happens, and there's a sense of humanity that we all want to hold on to you know. I still believe, I believe in it. I haven't thrown in the towel in terms of being resigned to technology or to a lifestyle which is technology driven, although that's what it is, that's where our life is going. And in reading some other material, I've been reading Yuval Harari is this really interesting

author who's getting some attention these days. He wrote a book called *Sapiens* and followed up with a book called *Homo Deus* and he talks about the synthesis of technology and biology. And it's really frightening where it goes. And it does relate to your question because it's harder and harder to hold on to that sense of what jazz and music represents about our species and our humanity you know, as technology encroaches. And so there are things, you know implants — I don't mean to get too off the subject here but what they're doing now is experiments with rats where they implant the electrodes that clip and will dispense serotonin from their brain to another part of their brain. So now you have a control panel, as if you were flying a drone, and the rat's in the cage, and you say, "Right turn," "Left turn," "Climb the stairs" and you push those buttons and that's exactly what the rat does. So that's a very frightening prospect. It's a little bit of a diversion from your question but I still think maybe tangentially related. Because, yet, it's a little hard for us to have this overwhelming aesthetic experience today. And I sort of feel protective of that experience and I'm hopeful that we will come out the other side and find some meeting ground, this technology evolves in the next fifty years that, the synthesis of man and machine is still of man. So I took your question out, sorry.

MR: No, that's okay. You know like when you take an improvisation out and you come back in.

TP: Oh yeah, this is a C seven chord. All right.

MR: The question of out and in, you played some things this morning, I should sort of describe, we were doing some things for the students under the auspices of our jazz professor Michael Woods. And I have this thing I do when someone plays something that I think is highly hip or unexpected or, in short, something I never would have thought of. And I find myself raising my eyebrows or, like turning my head. And you made me do that four or five times. And I just wanted to compliment you on the way you took things sort of out and brought them back in, and sometimes it happened really quickly. Is there a question here? There might be. Do you have a thought process when you improvise?

TP: I think like any improviser it's not on a conscious level. Things become habitual. You're — manipulating parameters becomes habitual. You don't think about the notes in a chord or a scale or which finger to push down to play when you improvise. But you think about the concept and the idea. But on the broader sense, not just playing an instrument and negotiating the changes, on a broader sense the same thing can happen in composition where you make it a habit of thinking consciously at first about texture, about displacement of rhythmic motifs by a different place in the meter, or augmentation. You know all these compositional techniques and you start to hone them just like you do a 2 — 5 — 7 lick and it becomes under your hand and you can spit it out in any key any

tempo, because you've got it. The same thing can happen compositionally when you start, you know you almost run through this checklist in a nanosecond about what's at play right now in terms of composition, and then make decisions that are appropriate. That's — I'd like to say that I aspire toward that. Sometimes it happens you know, but that I think is starting now. I think about myself as not an instrumentalist so much as just as a musician. And the same principles — that's the cool thing — the same principles apply negotiating a jazz solo that apply to Palestrina or James Brown or Henry Moore or Becket. I mean it's all the same — Debussy or Monet. I mean it's all the same stuff and finding a commonality in all these things over you know centuries and centuries, thousands of years. And again, I took your question out a little bit and yes there was a question, but it's not at a conscious level. I don't think about doing things a little differently and affect it at a conscious level, it just sort of happens now. But to get to that point I have gone through the process of thinking about it consciously. I have a little advantage because I've been a composition professor for twenty years. You know, so I've gotten a release from having to run my changes, you know just play the changes over a solo. I mean I really have to think about this stuff slowly and deliberately with students, and consequently it goes into me more.

MR: Excellent.

TP: So maybe that's part of your question.

MR: It is. I wonder, how long is your memory —

TP: What?

MR: When you're improvising. Good one. That was quick. If you're improvising and you do a particular thing and it worked, then you're moving on. You know there's this term like we're in the moment. But there was a moment a few seconds ago or a few measures ago then you did something, can I safely say that that doesn't leave your memory? Because you may want to do it again or you may not want to do it again.

TP: Well I aspire toward being in a place where I can actually make that decision, rather than have me just speak on in the other place. When you have the larger picture you realize that it's happened, then as you said, you see whether it's relevant. If it has relevance as you move forward or not. But yes, if it's not too far away I might remember it and use it or not. So I don't know quite how to get to that or change it. We all, we have patterns you know. We all are — we perceive patterns, amazingly, through a variety of senses, and relate to them. I mean I can speak very specifically about musical patterns and changes and notes and chords and motifs and all that stuff, but just generally human creatures are great at perceiving these patterns and when there's a pattern, the great choreographer Agnes DeMille said when there's a pattern there's an expectation. Every time you have a pattern you've created an expectation. So that's I think to the core of your question, it's

just being conscious of those expectations and then translating it to my little thing or our little thing about playing jazz you know. As I said it can be any aspect of art or life you know.

MR: What about the level of emotion in a jazz solo? I read over the years, I've read over the years jazz musicians play how they feel. Do you think the way you feel on any particular day affects significantly the way you improvise?

TP: Yes. I do. And I have two responses to this. One about the idea of playing the emotions in general. I'm going to come back to that. But the idea of being tuned into your particular day and where you are. Every — we're different this moment than you were ten minutes ago or at nine o'clock in the evening. If you're tuned in you're more responsive, you're more alert, you might be — it's time for dinner and I haven't eaten, I'm hungry, I'm going to be a little bit less responsive, perhaps less articulate here. So you know where your limit is. Sometimes you can't go as far as you did when you are at a peak moment. And you have to honor that and go with it. It's a little frustrating sometimes. And then other times you tune in and you know you can push the envelope a little bit more you know. But if you're on stage and you're trying to do good you want to push the envelope a little bit beyond that envelope, fall down and recover quickly, just teetering on the edge. You don't want to just stay back here in safe land. I'm hopeful — that line — what I'm getting at is that line changes.

MR: I see.

TP: So in terms of your emotion, your cognitive ability, your physical ability that day, that line is always moving around you know. You can't run a marathon if you didn't sleep or you have a bad knee or whatever. You have to be conscious of that situation and honor it. Sometimes it is frustrating and sometimes it's exhilarating. In terms of playing emotion I don't try to do things. I think I — there are certain composers and approaches to things where you try to extract emotion, where emotion is a detriment to the goal. We don't even think like that in music, but Schoenberg might be — the idea of tension and release, it wasn't something that he concerned himself with at all. I mean you know? You try to have this sameness or even if you look back in the music, although impressionistic music was emotional, there's a kind of sameness about the amorphous nature of a whole tone scale. You don't know where one is, and you don't know where Do is, you know, where the tonality is. So in a certain sense it sort of messes with your definitive, "We are home now," emotional resolution.

MR: Yeah it's noncommittal.

TP: Right. And it makes it more murky which is the intention of impressionism, to suggest rather than describe. So, and then the other thing or emotions of course if you're doing meditation or Buddhist people — you know I'm not a practicing Buddhist or anything,

but you know if you extract that from your — get rid of the longing you know, as they say, as it's said, perhaps it can open up a little avenue to get to someplace else. You're not distracted by the longings or emotions. But the first thing is, to answer your question more directly, I'm really taking this whole thing out, but yes, I think I am emotional when I play and it just sort of happens. I don't try to do this or try to do that, but when a phrase gets to a certain place and there's a dominant chord building up and you throw out some more plus nines and flat thirteens, and the drummer's thrusting you know, if resolution happens of course it's emotional. I mean I confess to being sort of old school in that way, and I guess I'm proud of that. You know that's sort of who I am. Other people might be more wholly intellectual. But it's a combination of things for me, to find that balance. I mean music is, jazz is a very intellectual endeavor you know.

MR: Indeed.

TP: It's incredible. I'm obviously very emotional.

MR: People think they just play what they want, and I'm not sure that most people realize how many sort of guidelines are going on at most times, and you're putting your skill into negotiating them and then trying to play with some emotion, or as this book I'm trying to make my way through, they call it storytelling.

TP: By?

MR: This is by a European musician, Sven Bearsted, and it's a whole book about storytelling in jazz improvisation.

TP: Oh. That's great, a great way to look at it, probably the most viable way to look at it. It's so easy to get consumed with negotiating the right chord, the right changes, the right scale for this — you have to go through all that stuff. But ultimately, as I was saying earlier today, it's about relating and telling a story, and a story is a narrative, and it's the narrative that always captures our attention more than information, more than basic information. It's the story that will capture your attention. All right? And most of the narrative is in the melody in a typical context be it a Mozart opera or a jazz solo, most of the time it's in the melody. Sometimes it's not, it doesn't have to be. But yeah, it's about storytelling. Storytelling trumps (I don't mean to use that word).

MR: We've just entered the world —

TP: It becomes more important than any other aspect, including just delivering raw information.

MR: Yeah. Is that the same parameter for your compositions? You are trying to tell a story and do you feel that in most moments of your composing that there is a dominant melody?

TP: Yeah. I mean you know in this contemporary world there's all kinds of ways to approach a conversation. I guess I feel like somewhat of a traditionalist in that sense. I like melodies. They still speak to me. I spend a lot of time trying to shape a melody, as a

composer, that is whole and cohesive and you know it reaches. And I think about why. Aaron Copland said, in '37 or something, he said, "Well we really don't know why a melody affects us but you know when it does it's really good." Since that time we've done a lot of research. And I happen to teach melody writing, which I love to do at both the graduate and undergraduate level. So I've thought about this a lot. Now we've been able to actually figure out psychologically and sociologically why we like certain melodies and sort of really dissect things in terms of contour and cultural implications and expectations you know. Because there are reasons why we like certain melodies, and I was surprised when I first read that Aaron Copland, who wrote some really incredible melodies, and he said, "Oh I just do this and it happens and if it works, great." But to do it consistently over time.

MR: Yeah. I'm going to pause for one second to turn off this fan.

TP: So Monk, and I talking about too much non-jazz stuff here?

MR: No, no, this is what I like.

TP: Okay because I can tell jazz stories too you know.

MR: No. I like this stuff. Because other people will like it, not just music fans, other profs etcetera. Okay. So you've got a long list of people that have played with you and people that you've played with and I wanted to ask you about how George Shearing came into your life.

TP: It sort of was a surprise. When I was at Eastman Marian McPartland came through with her trio. It was Rick Petrone and Joe Corsello the other members. And they gave a little workshop and I sat in on the vibraphone and that was — to call it basic would be a polite description. I mean I didn't know anything. I was pretty Neanderthal on the instrument at that time. I learned, I got more finesse later. But she remembered it, so George needed a vibraphone player for a quintet a year or two later and I guess he called Marian, and I'm in my apartment in New York and I get a call and it's George Shearing's manager and he's coming to do the "Today Show" would you like to audition for the quintet tomorrow? I said, "Great, sure, why not. Who's George Shearing?" I mean I'd heard of George Gershwin. I was such a neophyte and then I quickly, you know immediately learned all about Berlin and started looking at "Conception," oh my God, I've got to play this stuff? And I found out very quickly and I showed up and managed to play well enough to get the gig. So like the next week I'm in Los Angeles, you know, playing with the quintet and I'm just about shaking in my boots because, you know, and that's how I learned about this. Then I realized that incredible contribution and the long legacy of this guy's career. And even later I'll tell you more stories, but the depth of his ability was really quite remarkable. So I'm in the quintet and we used to play, you know, the music, if you look at the music, you don't have to learn everything but the music stand

[percussive scats], as you know the way he would play is [percussive scats], but this was continuing, right, and the whole front line had to do that together. So George would be playing this lock hand position and the vibraphone and guitar had to play absolute unison with that, in that kind of — and there's no way, it's impossible. So you learn to listen in a really intense way. And after one or two times, and you didn't rehearse. It was like the first, I'm doing this, there's an audience and we're trying to like negotiate — it's terrifying. I saw one guitar player come onto the band, he turned white. I could see his face was white. I had been in the band for a year and he was doing the same thing. I had known the book by that point. So and then you get it. And then after a while you get it. So it's a kind of, that nuanced application of time, the process of learning it was really hard, you have to listen so intensely. It's like a tango people, not a tango show but a real tango dancer — I mean they are so tuned into each other and to the music. It's just incredible.

MR: Well that Shearing sound you know, that famous — was the vibe, were the vibes and the guitar usually playing the same octave or were you guys in octaves and is that what partly made that sound?

TP: I think this was an error because as you know the guitar transposes an octave up. You write it an octave up.

MR: Right.

TP: So I think the guitar player played, when he wrote the music it came down. And I was playing with the piano and the guitar player, I believe that was an error in the beginning that became a sound and he milked it for a zillion years and it was a very cool thing. And he's just a — I mean people call it "polite jazz." During the height of his career he was criticized for being polite. It was too packaged. It was so, almost sweet. But this guy, I could tell you in simple terms, this guy could really play, and had an intellect that was incredible. And the story, sometimes I tell the story, he was playing with Andy Simpkins at a place called the Matador and he was using the quintet. It was Rusty Jones, Andy Simpkins, Billy Rodgers the guitar player from Omaha, myself and George. So he and Andy, George and Andy were playing at the Matador in San Francisco, and the next day the quintet was going on a tour, we were all getting on the bus and going to Seattle or something. So I walk into the club in San Francisco, and the manager goes over to George's ear and says, "It's a little tense here." So he says to the audience, live, he says "Well our vibraphonist is here, we're going to start our tour tomorrow with the quintet, and in Ted's honor we're going to play an arrangement that he did for the quintet." I said great. And the previous tour, a few months before, I had done this elaborate arrangement of "Autumn Leaves" and it was a three part counterpoint that went on and on between the

piano, the guitar and the vibes. And we all danced around each other like contrapuntal music —

MR: Written out?

TP: Oh yeah, written out. I mean not just the blowing part, but this was before, over the chorus or something. But it went on for several choruses. Right? I studiously, I worked really hard on this thing and it was sort of cool you know. And yet, and he says this to the audience, and then he sits down and he plays all three parts flawlessly. He had never played them before. He had heard them, because we had done them on the tour, but he just goes bamm, and the entire fugue happened, right? Right there in front of my ears and I went [gestures] my jaw just — and then I realized who I'm dealing with. This is like Mozart, I mean this guy has some kind of processing power that's really magnificent.

MR: That's a good way to put it, processing power.

TP: Oh my gosh. It was amazing. And so I loved my time, I learned a lot, I wish I had been a bit more mature, I would have learned more you know. I wish I had been really ready, a more mature musician, and when I entered the quintet you know I was a little young and restless and anxious to play my four mallet stuff you know. But I learned so much about music from George, and just sensitivity and certainly you know playing in an ensemble, ensemble playing, you have to be, as I indicated. But the music got a little, you know, we played some Chick Corea, we played "Freedom Jazz Dance" and, but a lot of the stuff we did was pretty mild you know. [Scats], and I'd play these little parts and I would look at the drummer, Rusty. We'd be on stage and he would get it, his timing was so great. Just as I'd look at him he would get a nod, as if he's falling off asleep, he's going [gestures] and I don't know if he knew it was going to make me laugh you know. And then we'd turn on and George would play "Conception" or something and just tear it up.

MR: I see.

TP: So, and he was just phenomenal. And I was sort of wanting to experiment with four mallets and you only play two mallets with that band. I would hold four but I would only play the line. Sometimes with a solo you would occasionally play some chords, but I wasn't anxious to go out.

MR: So you spent how many —

TP: I spent three years during that turn with him and we toured all over South America and all through Europe and all through the United States. We did community concert tours, sometimes three months at a clip where you're out and you call a desk at the Holiday Inn and ask them what state you're in. You just get really confused.

MR: Wow. I'm happy to say he received an honorary degree here.

TP: Really?

MR: Yes, along with Joe Williams and a number of other musicians.

TP: It's funny, my experience with that band and with George was more impactful actually to me, years after I left the band. It's where I really started to think about it. Where it happened you know and how much I really learned. I didn't think about how much I learned by the example of sort of stellar musicianship and good taste. That's what he — you know, and how to handle an audience, he had his typical jokes but, you know, "Have you been blind all your life?" "Not yet." "The proceeds from tonight's concert will be going to the blind. Not all the blind" you know, the typical — he had a shtick you know.

MR: Yes. He told this funny — Joe Williams interviewed him for us. And it was a great session and he told some things about his childhood and playing in an all-blind band. And we weren't sure that — is he making this stuff up?

TP: I read that interview in this archive.

MR: Even Joe said, "Oh come on, George."

TP: Yeah he started at the beginning.

MR: You mentioned a guy from, you know upstate New York had a lot of great musicians come out of here, mostly Italians, like the Romanos and the Brignolas. You mentioned Nick Brignola. And man he could play that horn.

TP: He was amazing. I loved the way he played. I had the opportunity for a number of years to direct a big band, the Aspen Festival. And we'd have, you know Joe Williams came and Clark Terry, and I had great people that came out, it was really a privileged position, it was wonderful. And Nick came out, I had him come out one time and he was just great with the band, just nailed it, wowed everybody with his showmanship and his improvisation. But he had a way, the story I have is he had one distinctive thing — he didn't want, once you got a sound in a sound check, that was it. He hated the guy in the back moving the faders. Because once he got a sound, he knew what the balance was, he would move back to the microphone — so we had the sound check, doing it, and he traveled with this, he got in a pawn shop, some kind of rinky-dink little mixing board that he bought for a couple of dollars you know, and so when we got the sound check he got off the stage and he went to the guy in the back and he said, "Here." He put it right here. "You want move something, you move that during the concert. You want to move some faders, there you go." And the guy said, "Okay Mr. Brignola."

MR: Kenny Davern was like that.

TP: That's great.

MR: The idea that someone else is going to control your sound and your volume, like musicians like to work the mic. And vocalists — I mean I remember Joe Williams singing, he was here and he was singing — he had the mic at his belt level, right? And he was doing it on purpose. He was using that — so that's a good story.

TP: I mean just the experience, just to have done that for fifty or sixty years. I've heard George, I brought him to another institution to do a clinic and someone said, "How do you do that Mr. Shearing." He says, "You've just got to do it for about fifty or sixty years."

MR: You'll get there just keep doing it.

TP: Yeah, ten thousand hours to develop expertise is nothing at all.

MR: Something interesting happened this morning, and I found out afterwards and you and I shared an experience — when you got up and you were doing this little demonstration about the beat and how it can — you know you had the student between two chairs going twelve steps and then changing. Eventually the destination was the same. That exercise — when I saw you do that I said I wonder if you worked in aesthetic education — because I did and when I saw you do that I said I bet he did. And then I went up and I re-read your bios and it said indeed you worked or work for the Lincoln Center Arts in Education mode. And I did that here in Utica for many years.

TP: Isn't that inter — I'm so delighted that you picked up on that. And I'm thrilled that you see that and that you went back and made that connection.

MR: Well the idea of trying to relate to get non-musicians to understand musical concepts is a wonderfully challenging endeavor I think. And it makes you think different about them I believe.

TP: Right. The Center for Arts in Education used to be called Lincoln Center Institute years ago. And my wife, who is a modern dancer, is still working for them. She was one of the first pioneers at that, and I came in and did a few years' work with them. But she just breathes these concepts. And I've learned a lot. I've gone to a zillion dance concerts. It's all the same, but yes I did do that kind of work and I love it. And there was a subsidiary in Lincoln, Nebraska called the Lead Institute, the Lead Center. And they would bring us out and we would team teach. I did it also at Lincoln Center at Juilliard. But the model was you have four artists come out of theater, you know, an actor, a visual artist, a dancer and a musician, and you have this group of sixth grade teachers for two weeks. And every day you do a workshop in the morning one discipline after another discipline, and you create work. You examine works of art. You create work. You talk about these concepts. And that thinking in aesthetic education, again, it was formative for me. I didn't realize how important it was until I really, I realized I was thinking like that the whole time, how everything is related you know, how these cross disciplines, even on the bandstand, it doesn't matter whether it's, and I truly believe whether it's this jazz solo or a painter. It doesn't make that much difference. But those concepts and thinking in large artistic parameters like gee freedom and discipline are patterns and expectations. And something stays the same and something changes and you know all those things, they've inspired

and in a certain sense directed a lot of my compositional thinking and sometimes my soloing too. And also it saved my tail when I became a composition professor because I wrote through a department called Studio Composition. And most of my constituents, certainly in the beginning, were singers, songwriters, rock & roll, indie bands, movie scoring people, people who write for video games you know. And so what do I know? I don't know. I came up with — I listened to Bill Evans and Clark Terry and you know, what do I know about this stuff. But teaching in those large concepts, like somebody, to put it simply, composition is composition. It doesn't matter. Composition is composition. And so I was able to use those concepts from the Lincoln Center Institute in order to address and hopefully contribute something meaningful to this program, rather than me being able to quote all the artists that they knew — I didn't know them, I didn't know them. I'm in the jazz world. My formative years were in the jazz world. But those concepts got me through and they're still my guiding light in a lot of ways. You know and it's old school, it's nothing new. Thousands of years I mean, it worked for Palestrina, these things.

MR: I totally agree and I learned so much from working with like — I had the same exact scenario working with classroom teachers. And there's nothing like getting their — the questions they ask or the — like I remember doing a thing one day and I kept using the word "melody." Finally, bless her heart, some teacher said, like, excuse me but, "What's a melody?" And it was like this, oh man, this realization, that, find a way to not just use your own lingo. And boy that was very valuable.

TP: Right. And you know so you can't communicate directly, like that. So you sit and find a way maybe to find some commonality and what happens is then you can cultivate an exchange. An exchange that wouldn't have happened otherwise.

MR: Right.

TP: And the feeling that you have exchanging and knowing a little bit more about each other wouldn't have happened. That's why it's important.

MR: Yeah. What's your take on the scenario where a parent comes to you and you've been teaching their son or daughter and the son or daughter wants to go into music full time. They want to be — they want to make it in the music business. And you may have an opinion about that depending on how you feel their talent level is. Are you able to be honest with them?

TP: If I can't be honest I'm not worth anything to them as a professor. My obligation is to be honest. My obligation is also to tell them what I know and to help arm them with as many skills as they can have to pursue their dreams and careers. Will I talk honestly about the nature of the business? Of course. It's a horrendous way to make a living if you — in a lot of ways. It's also a beautiful way to make a living. But yeah, any profession has to

deal with this. And you could make it drive you crazy. In a way I'm preparing these people for a profession — a profession that doesn't exist. I mean all the jazz musicians go through that. What are you going to — you're going to go pay for your kids' college and health insurance for the next twenty years by playing a local club? Good luck. When there are like eight thousand people that play just as well as you and might be cuter and know the owner? I mean those are the realities of things. I talk about them and I say this is the way it is, but at the same time I talk about what I am privileged to do and I share it as best I can and maybe some of that enthusiasm comes — I mean some people are just born performers. I get students, they're going to do this. No matter how crazy it is, they're going to do this. But I will help them and you know that's my job as well as to be an artist. So I think the honesty is important. I can follow up with a joke, this is a stupid joke but I'll tell you. So a young guy comes up and asks his dad, "Dad, when I grow up I want to be a jazz musician." The father says, "Well son, you can't do both."

MR: Ta-da boom.

TP: Boom-chick-a-boom.

MR: That's good.

TP: I don't know if that's relevant or not but I wish I had a great answer to fix this dilemma. I mean obviously it's a societal problem and I could level my opinions about what the difference is between here and in Europe and about where we're going culturally in this country and world-wide. That's just not, it's not going to fix the problem.

MR: I've had a little — some dilemmas over the years with certain players who are really quite accomplished and they want to pursue this. And I'm torn about focusing on making them — continuing on the path of being the best player on their instrument they can, as opposed to the approach well if you want to make a living in music you have to be a good player but you also ought to, like okay, you should learn the piano. You should learn to take horn parts off the record. You should learn to do X and Y and Z and you'll have a better chance of actually making a living than if you're just a great saxophone player.

TP: I agree. And I think I've been lucky and perhaps a little selfish to extract myself from that responsibility of taking it upon myself how to teach them how to make a living. Because it's not the best thing I could do for them. I think the best thing I could do for them, my students, is to share my love of what I do and tell them all I know about the best — as honestly as I can. I think there are other people that can do that much better than I, and I agree with you, coming out equipped to make a living is a different skill. But I think, at least what I try to do is to help people, like my wife does, find more about their creative self, and find that fulfillment and the joy of being able to you know, create something artistically and share it and get the satisfaction from it. That's something I can try to help people do better than making a living. And I'm not — in a certain sense I'm skirting the

responsibility but that's not what I do best. You know? That's not what I do best I don't think.

MR: Well people have to find their own way to some extent anyway. I just sometimes worry about — I might have had the next you know really big player under my tutelage and I sort of took them on the broad path instead of the narrow path. Of course normally if I get a really, really good student, I tell them they need to go to somebody else if they get to a point where I can't help you anymore.

TP: Well yeah, we all should do it. It happens to me too, it's great. Since we're talking about education I'm going to a conservatory and it's a bunch of race horse types, all trying to win you know, they really are taking it — involved with music and be, whatever. The skill will be moving all those great demands and be a fine musician. And most of the rewards, courses that I took as an undergraduate, were adequate to say the least. I mean there were a couple of wonderful professors that I had, but Eastman, that's not what they do. And so I feel like I had to make up for that, for the rest of my life in a certain sense, so you know I'm still a student trying to read a little bit here and there and learn how life works and sort of fill out that liberal arts education, which a conservatory doesn't really give you. In some curriculums, some five year programs exist that do that in certain places. But you know you can't — what's the right balance? What's the right call for each individual? You don't know that. But for me I've had to make up for that a little bit and it's been joyous along the way, but there's more to just being a great musician. I think it's important to be many other things.

MR: You have a 30-year-old daughter you said?

TP: I do.

MR: Did she learn the word "gig" early on, as a kid.

TP: She learned the word "gig" right now because she's in a gig economy.

MR: Isn't that interesting.

TP: The term has been usurped by economists and people who are writing. I mean now you see it in — she is a filmmaker.

MR: I said, "What do you mean a gig economy?" And then it was explained to me and I said, oh yeah that's what musicians —

TP: That's right. And she is a filmmaker and she is doing human rights work. She's doing some really fascinating work, of course I'm very proud of her. But you know the assignments are a year, six months, four months, some of them have health insurance, some of them don't, but they're not a tenure track position for a company or a university. They're until this project gets finished, and some projects are longer than others. And she is like in there doing it at a high level. But the whole parameter, the whole paradigm has shifted to a gig economy and now we're going to start talking about economics and it'll

be a little bit of a diversion from the task here, but it's really changing things a lot in this country and changing how we all look at our future.

MR: Well I know you have to be on your way to your next gig in this gig economy, but I do want to give you an opportunity — I'll bet you have an opinion about the current state of affairs in our country in a broad sense if you feel like talking about it for a minute.

TP: Well this is very interesting because you always — you know we go to these dinner parties or cocktail parties or just happen to meet somebody at Starbucks and you do this dance until you find out what political side the person you're addressing is on. And you're afraid this is a trepidation, oh my God, oh no, I don't want to blow this relationship, I don't want — they're going to hate me — or great, I'm going to have a compadre where we can talk about how horrible things are. So it happens every day because of the intense polarization we have today. Every day. It happened to me this morning with, you know, and people that I really love and really respected, I didn't know, and because time was limited I decided we're not going to go there. Like I was talking about earlier in the plane. You don't want to spoil, you don't want to cause a tense situation. So now here I am, I don't know if this is an audience, but you give me a chance to express my political views. I will, and I am not in any way happy with this administration. The sooner we get back to the values, the real values of this country, which means honoring the constitution and the separation of powers and, and when you look at — you give me a soapbox but the, in terms of our environment for our grandchildren and their kids, rather than the corporate dollar. Those types of things are vitally important. We have usurped so much of our power and our moral — the morality, because of what we stand for that had sway that has been just so quickly spent and squandered. So there I go with my opinions about this thing. Maybe I've made an enemy of you. I don't know. But you asked me. That's how I feel. And then sometimes, oh great, when we feel the same we can talk about it. But I find it deeply troubling. And I think if I didn't have children I'd say hey may I've been lucky, I've had a wonderful experience, I've lived a good life, I'll be checking out pretty soon and thank you very much and it's been great. I care about the future generations and I do care about this American experiment and it's one empire, it's one civilization in four thousand years of stuff it's been going on. Nothing lasts forever. I know all that. But I do care about it and it's troubling to see things go south at this point. I think it's vitally important that we act pretty soon and I encourage all of you, whoever reads this, it might be past election time, or sees this thing, I hope you do vote. For about six months before an election I go to school every day with —I don't preach but I just have a shirt that says "Vote."

MR: Well your sentiment has my vote. All right?

TP: Well thank you. And I hope I didn't make any enemies and if I did forgive me, sir.

MR: No, no. What's the very next thing on your plate?

TP: I have to go to Rochester.

MR: To Eastman?

TP: Yeah, I'm going to Eastman and then after that I go back home and start teaching. And then I'm getting together thoughts for another album. I'm planning — I don't know which way I should go. I have all this chamber music I want to do and Argentinean — I do a lot of tangos. So I'm starting to work with these people now in New York and development of those connections and I don't know if I want to do a chamber music album, different than it was with Argentinean influence. By the way the last album was recorded in Buenos Aires and then I came back and added some of the American guys you know. But the basic tracks were done down there and we toured it and it was really fun. So between that and doing an album with four horns and just a regular straight ahead jazz septet kind of album so we're deciding which one and looking for funding, how to make this happen. I feel pretty fortunate to be able to keep doing this. That's what I can say, yeah.

MR: Well that's a good note to wrap up on. Thank you very much.

TP: My great pleasure.